

In פרשת ויקהל, which details the construction of the משכן, we find a repetition of what was commanded in תרומה - except here, בני ישראל actually carried out the task, fulfilling Hashem's ציווי to the highest level. However, there was one aspect that was not done as perfectly as it could have been, and the פסוק points it out explicitly. It says (35:27), וְהַנְשָׂאִים הָבִיאוּ אֶת אֲבִנֵי הַשֹּׁהַם, the נשיאים brought the אבני השהם required for the כהן גדול of the כהונה. The only problem is, if you look carefully, the word נְשָׂאִים is missing a ״ - it's חסר. רש"י comments that the נשיאים were punished because נְתַעְצְלוּ - they were lazy. Why? They made a calculation and said, "Everyone is donating, let's wait and see what is still missing, and then we will provide whatever is lacking."

R' Reuven Grozovsky, brought down in the ספר פנינים משלחן גבוה, was a ראש ישיבה in Kaminetz and later in America at ישיבת תורה ודעת. He provides a fascinating הערה. He explains that the נשיאים had a seemingly valid and thoughtful reason for waiting. They were not lacking concern or interest. However, that was not what was demanded of them. The expectation was not to wait until something was lacking, but rather to act immediately with זריזות.

R' Label Lam brings a משל quoted in a Torah Anytimes issue (Bo 5785), that is related to this topic: "I didn't catch all of the heartwarming drama in shul on Friday night, but my son filled me in later. There was a young man with Down Syndrome who desperately wanted to lead the ציבור in קבלת שבת, but he wasn't really capable of doing so on his own. So what did they do? They put a טלית on him, and he stood next to the חזן, who guided him through the entire תפילה, singing alongside him. When the service was over, everyone gathered around him to give him a שכורה, to thank him, to make him feel like he had done something extraordinary. And he did. He felt amazing. My son later turned to me and said, 'Abba, that's exactly how it is with us. Hashem does everything, and yet even our small participation is enough to create the appearance that we accomplished something ourselves.'"

What is a person's תפקיד in this world? It is not to fix the world or to supply what is missing - הקדוש ברוך הוא has the ability to do all of that. Our תפקיד is to fix and perfect ourselves. The number one way to do this is through זריזות. If a מצוה comes your way, don't let it get old, don't let it become חמץ. When בני ישראל were מצווה to bring the תרומה for the משכן, the purpose was not the actual building itself. Hashem did not need their donations or their labor to build a משכן. Rather, He was giving them an opportunity - an opportunity to refine themselves, to give of themselves, to grow spiritually. This is particularly significant in the aftermath of חטא העגל. The נשיאים, by delaying their participation, missed this crucial aspect of the מצוה. They failed to seize the moment with זריזות, and as a result, their name was written חסר in the פסוק.

This idea of זריזות is not just theoretical - it has real הלכה implications. The ספר פנינים משלחן גבוה quotes a תוספות, which says that if someone has the opportunity to do a מצוה, but in doing so he will transgress a לא תעשה, the principle of עשה דוחה לא תעשה applies. However, תוספות asks: Is it preferable to delay the מצוה until it can be performed without violating the לא תעשה, or should it be done immediately, even if it means relying on the לא תעשה? The conclusion is that זריזות takes precedence - it is better to perform the מצוה immediately, even if it means relying on the principle of לא תעשה. Here's a practical application of this principle. Suppose someone discovers that his ציצית contains שעטנז. He intends to replace them with a kosher בגד, but the new one will not be available for another day, or even an hour. What should he do? Is it better for him to wait until he can wear 100% kosher ציצית, avoiding any transgression? Or should he wear the שעטנז ציצית in the meantime, fulfilling the מצוה of ציצית but relying on the לא תעשה? Rabbi Oelbaum said that it's clear from this תוספות that it's better for him to do the מצוה now with the שעטנז ציצית and depend on the לא תעשה, and do the מצוה with זריזות. I hope we don't have that specific problem, I hope all of our ציצית are not שעטנז. But meanwhile, that is what תוספות says. You can look it up. תוספות says this in שבת, דף ג ע"א, ד"ה ועל הזקן שתים מכאן. Im Yirtzeh Hashem, we should be זוכה to always fulfill the השם in the best possible way.

